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Joe Ascione

Joe Ascione is one of the in-demand drummers in jazz today. His versatility has enabled him to record with a lengthy list of diverse artists including Donald Fagen, Ruby Braff, Dick Hyman and Dr. John. Joe appears at major jazz festivals here and abroad and regularly presents drum clinics to aspiring musicians across the country.

Joe was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 17, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in Clearwater Beach. My name is Monk Rowe for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm pleased to have Joe Ascione here.

JA: Nice to be here.

MR: I was just reading the list of people you've played with and I'm jealous.

JA: Thank you for being jealous.

MR: Great, man. How do you go about making your reputation in today's jazz world?

JA: I think ultimately the musical playing experience is the musician's greatest asset. So more often than not people I've had the opportunity to play with have been people that, either through recommendation and then a great musical experience would occur, and then from there word spreads. It's more word of mouth. There is no school for something like that. Occasionally it's through the distant recommendation, but more often than not from a good musical experience I'll get a return call or through that word of mouth promoter or tour director or record date, fellow musician. That's the greatest tool.

MR: A lot of the guys are going the jazz college route these days.

JA: Um hum.

MR: Did you do that?

JA: I aspired to do that. I had several scholarships to a few of the top places. I ultimately stayed in New York, Long Island proper, at Hofstra University. They had a pretty good jazz program. The reason being, I was studying with Charlie Perry in the 70s and he said, "What do you want to do?" I said, "I want to play my drums." He said, "Stay in New York. If you go to college good for you, it'll be a positive thing." He said, "If you go away there's one philosophy you can come back four years later and say 'here's my paper' and yay, or," he said, "why don't you stay here and start playing and develop the craft and go that route." So I did. I think of myself taking the middle of the road. No, it's an intermediate road. Some players just came up through the school of the street and that was it. Other players came the route of the college and getting picked up by a big band, let's say the Buddy Rich Big Band or Woody Herman or whomever, or forming groups

themselves. I sort of have taken the route of both of them. I'm street wise and gig chops experienced and yet I have the school background also. But I stayed in New York predominantly through that period.

MR: Did you play a lot of dues paying kind of gigs along the way like you should I guess?

JA: Oh yeah. Absolutely. My first professional gig I was twelve. My dad used to take me, God bless him. He would take me. But I made a fatal mistake. The gentleman who hired us was the house billiards champion. And I grew up with a pool table. And this little twelve year old kid was just excited to (a) be playing drums and (b) see a pool table. So I went there and begged him to play and the guy played me and I beat him. So that was a good lesson.

MR: You actually beat him?

JA: I really did. I really did. I make a joke that I put myself through school playing pool. But yeah, I started at a young age. Started playing at four but started playing professionally at twelve doing gigs around the Long Island area and just kept going from there.

MR: What was the music being played in your house when you grew up?

JA: Swing slash jazz, if we had to put a title to it.

MR: Really?

JA: Well that from my parents, and also the indigenous Italian folk music and some opera and my sister, who is about six years older than I am, she listened to the pop music of the day. So I had a fairly good cross section of music.

MR: Is your family background strongly Italian?

JA: Yup. Yes. Strong Italian, strong culturally musical. My maternal grandfather played literally just about every instrument. And now you're saying okay, harp, oboe, you know, cello. Yeah, harp, oboe, cello, mandolin, violin, guitar, piano. He played them all, well too. And my grandmother, this is funny, my grandmother played tambourine in Italy. And she was a great tambourine player, if you could believe it, I mean all the rolls.

MR: Oh, with the head on it, yeah.

JA: She could play. She could play a tambourine. My father's father played bass drum in the Italian marching band. And my uncles played guitar. But when everyone got together in the big Italian families they played guitar, sang Italian tunes and sang and danced and things like that. So there was always a happy musical environment.

MR: Yeah. So it's in your genes.

JA: Perhaps so. And all my cousins play drums. I think only one at this point plays semi-professionally. But it was always around — when I was four I saw one of my cousins and it was like the heavens parted and I knew — if I only knew one thing in my life I knew I was going to play drums.

MR: And that — how old were you then?

JA: I was four. And that Christmas I was nice enough to get a little kid drum set. They told me at a year and a half I was keeping a steady beat on a drum and who knows. I took a two and a half year hiatus at the ripe age of four. But it was always around, music and drums. But I just knew, I just felt comfortable there.

MR: When it came time for a choice of career, was your family supportive?

JA: They were always supportive and they strongly invited and suggested that at least I get a college degree. Well they were looking out for my best interests I'm sure, just for my own edification. And I'm a fairly sensible person, give or take. So it made sense to me. And I just have sort of an intellectual curiosity as far as, every now and then I get an academic itch so I scratch it. I went to engineering school and got a degree, worked at an insurance company for a while at one point which I didn't really care for but it was a good experience. Went and got a real estate license in between a cruise with Flip Phillips. I took the book on the boat, just to keep myself interested and read. So I like doing stuff like that on my own. But I know not to develop another career path, it's just some interests.

MR: Wow. That's very interesting.

JA: But I've always known I wanted to play drums. That was it.

MR: When was the first, what you would consider to be a breakthrough job for you?

JA: Okay, this one always comes to mind. When I was young studying with Charlie Perry, I was about seventeen, he always mentioned the tenor player Billy Mitchell, not the other Billy Mitchell, the tenor player Billy Mitchell with the Basie band. I think he was with Basie, what '57 to '61 give or take. But he lives on Long Island and I always knew of him. I think he replaced Buddy Tate at the time if I'm not mistaken.

MR: I think he did.

JA: So I always knew of him and Charlie Perry always used to say see if you can get to hook up with Billy. It never happened until a couple of years later, Sonny's Jazz Club on Long Island had Billy do a Wednesday night steady gig for a while. And somehow I got the call from Sonny, the owner. And he said, "Hey, Joe" real raspy voice, scotch-ladened voice, you know "Joey, baby, come on here and play with Billy." And I was nervous. So I'm sitting there and it's I think Wes Belcamp and Pete Chivoli who used to play with Stan Kenton for a while, Wes is a good piano player. Mark Elf, guitarist, and I'm sure there were other — Bill Easley might have come down and Frank Wess came down, a lot of those guys live out on Long Island. So I was there and I'm just, not wanting to keep it safe, but wanting to do the gig. So the first set goes by and no one attacked me, I didn't attack anyone. Things are good. I'm outside, I see Billy outside smoking, and mustered up the courage and I said, "Billy, I don't know what you're looking for, do you have any suggestions? Loud? Soft? Sticks? Brushes?" So he looks at me and he says, "You're the

drummer, play the drums." All right. So I walk in the house, in the place, scratching my head. I see Mark Elf, you're the drummer, play the drums. I say, "Mark, what the hell's this guy talking about? You're the drummer, play the drums?" He said, "Man you can't kick those tubs hard enough." He said, "He's played with Blakey and Elvin and Buddy Rich" and this and this. He said, "Just go, man, hit 'em." All right. Next set so I boom-boom, start bashing. "Yeah, yeah, all right." And by the end of that set he turned around and he said, "From now on you're my drummer." And I did like twelve years of Wednesday nights at Sonny's Jazz Club. So to me I think of that as a breakthrough for someone like a Billy Mitchell to be that excited musically. So that was great. And it was a good confidence builder too. So I say to myself well I can play with Billy Mitchell, he's okay with it, so let me venture out even more. So I would say that was a pivot point.

MR: Yeah. I like the way that the older fellas have a succinct way of telling you what they want.

JA: Yeah, yeah. And the older and wiser they are, the more open and sincere and genuine they are too. When I got to play with Jay McShann and Cab Calloway and Al Hirt and Milt Hinton and all those guys. They are great. Some of them aren't here and some are. Great, great, supportive people and encouraging and it's great to play with those people who are gems as people and musicians.

MR: Right. You have to bring — I'm quoting somebody and I can't remember who it is — but you have to bring a life to the music rather than just some technique.

JA: I agree.

MR: And that's what those guys have for sure.

JA: Yeah. And you could — I always use — well use the heart as the barometer, but when I come out feeling fulfilled and a sense of awe and wonder and excitement and joy, you know that the music spoke. And I even translate that to even drum clinics, outside of in the musical setting, with a group. When I come out and hear a real pure artist playing, even the drum kit at a clinic, if it's pure like that I come out fulfilled and energized. If I hear something that's just — it could be technically flawless — but if it's not emanating and coming from inside outwards it's almost premeditated. And I leave empty. So I use that as a barometer. And it's good to listen to the self. Because you catch it.

MR: Yeah. I imagine you try to give the same impression out of your own drum clinics then.

JA: Yeah. And for a while I couldn't do clinics because I was starting to play in a premeditated fashion. I'd get up there and start thinking about what I'm going to do instead of just being more in an affective tone. And I like to just be in the moment and sort of paint on the canvas and see what piece of art quote unquote is going to come out. So it's not too premeditated. We all go into our bag of tricks. We all have good days and

bad days. But more often than not when the ingredients are right and the cerebral switch is shut off you can just create.

MR: Is it possible to tell younger players what makes things swing?

JA: Well I know from some teaching that I do that when I hear somebody who just has the innate quality of knowing where the pulse is, sometimes I want to say you can't teach somebody to swing. Sometimes I say maybe you can. But I think everyone has this level of the ability to hear the full value of a quarter note let's say. And then some of them, you know make it stretch and breathe and time does expand and contract. We're not robots so it's not metronomic. I'd rather swing than play steady. Dig that. Because if something's swinging you're tapping your foot, you're excited, it's feeling good. Don't get me wrong, there's nothing like a drummer obviously keeping time, what other function is there? But I've heard — I remember this one brochure I had and they asked Benny Goodman and Louis Armstrong and Doc Severinsen, all these different band leaders, what do you look for in a drummer? What do you look for? And I would say two-thirds of them would rather hear somebody swing than keep time. Some of the, obviously they say you've got to have a great timekeeper. Of course you do. But if you heard a guy who's a great timekeeper but it's not swinging, that cat's not going to work. And if it is, I don't want to hear that band. But if you hear a band swinging, time expands and contracts. I don't want to say blatantly drag or rush, but it breathes. It's got a life to it. A heartbeat to it. So I'd rather hear something that's just swinging, the guys are playing together and everything's resonating and it's working and it's swinging.

MR: Is it hard to play with a click track because of that, time expanding and—

JA: Well I'll use a click track on a jingle, a movie thing, a contemporary setting, even a book, an instructional book project. So those type of things I'll use a click track. No I don't have a problem. I don't have a problem doing that. In fact I like it. It's kind of fun. It's easier than playing tennis. But for jazz, I don't really care to use it.

MR: No, I just wondered, you know because you were saying that the time can move a bit.

JA: Yeah.

MR: In a live situation, so.

JA: Right. Much more so.

MR: All right.

JA: I'll never practice — when I was a kid I had a teacher who said he went to I think Ithaca College perhaps. Greg Prios. Great teacher. Great musician, great teacher. And he said to me, "If you're practicing with records, don't use live recordings. More often than not the time is moving around more than you'd care to hear." And I stuck with that and it's sort of true. You can find great live recordings obviously that aren't like that, but more often

than not if I were going to practice something at a certain tempo to work out a brush stroke or just lock in a groove, I'd probably use something that was not live.

MR: In some of your promo material I read it says you're a protégé of Buddy Rich. Is that something that you would consider or is that something that people write, for something to write?

JA: Here's the true story. When I was a young boy Gene Krupa was my idol. I met him in 1971 when I was ten and then he died in '73 and I was really sad, and then I heard Buddy Rich, one of my male cousins who played drums gave me a record, a 1959 recording, "The Driver" it was called. Mike Mainieri, first record. Selden Powell, Earl May, McKenna. And it was like what is this, two, three drummers? I couldn't understand what was going on. My ear to the stereo. So he became my new guy. So then I got to hear him and meet him and things like that. When I was about eighteen a friend of mine and I, before I went to college, we started following his band around. And we would show up at gigs in the whole Northeast of America. And at one point he said, "Hey you guys here again?" But at the end of the night like you have all this gear here you've got to pack up so the guys in the band just want to go eat, get paid, get the hell out. So I helped him. You know, "Yeah, we'll help you load the stuff on the bus." The next night, "Hey, you guys—" "yeah, put it up there." And I just night after night gravitated towards the drum. Next thing you know I'm setting up the drums, breaking down the drums, setting up the angles, the heights, and getting everything right. And of course I did that to absorb that musical experience. And I remember taking pictures of it at all different angles when I was really into it. It was a good role model at the time when I was in my teens. So it was a function of that, of absorbing he and his music and that intense ability he had on the instrument, and that's what it was. That's what it was. I never looked to copy him, but just to try, if it were possible, to absorb some of that presence or that energy and that ability, that type of thing. I think good players copy great players steal.

MR: I want to think about that one for a minute.

JA: Well you can think about it.

MR: Good players copy?

JA: Yeah. You hear a lot of guys who sound exactly like this. They're good players but they're copying. They don't come into their own voice. But I love, I mean I still take lessons, I go to hear everyone, and I'll hear this Cuban guy do this and I'm like, I'm taking that. Or hear this guy, I'm talking— ooh check that out, what's this, how's that? And the drumming community is like that. We can sit down, check this riff out, this pattern, look at this. Bass players talk about the instrument, you know, a hundred twenty years old, check out the wood. Guitar players, they hide from the lick, they don't want you to copy their stuff. So everybody's got, you now, the proclivities of each musical

family. But the drummers share. But yeah I think good players copy, great players steal. But I wasn't a Buddy Rich protégé.

MR: The time that you were following him around, was that the big band, like with Don Menza and—

JA: Yeah. So I was seventeen, eighteen, so that's '78. Yeah 1978. Ross Konikoff was in the band. Steve Marcus.

MR: Yeah. It was a little after the time I was thinking of, but Menza was earlier of course.

JA: Yes he was. He was earlier. But it was great. It was great to hear that night after night. And I never talked drums with him, because it just — I'm fairly intuitive so there's a barometer, you can tell what the boundaries are. But I would observe, especially behind the instrument. But we played softball with the guys. Or he used to like to eat Creamsicles. So we'd stop at a town and I'd go to a deli and buy a whole box of Creamsicles. He'd take a big bite with those capped teeth, you remember stupid things. You'd see these big capped teeth marks in a Creamsicle you know. Throw a softball around. But I guess it was because I was just totally into — not because I was into the music or his drumming, but I was just so into being in that environment that I was really just sincere about that and just wanting that it wasn't an uncomfortable situation. And hell I was just going to be there to cop what I could.

MR: I've heard people say that he had extreme, could be extremely nice and then could be extremely not nice. Did you ever witness either one of those things?

JA: Yeah. All shades. I saw it go from good to bad and back to bad and into good. You know I really appreciate strong personalities, because you know where you stand. I mean there's a fine line between strong personality and psychosis being a little askew. But people are people.

MR: Right.

JA: But I think somebody who played at that level is going to have a strong personality. People play their personalities. I think people play their personalities. You meet someone who's got a wishy-washy handshake and kind of — they're going to play, their horn like that. You meet somebody like, well talking about Buddy Rich, there's going to be some fire behind the kit.

MR: He was pretty self taught musically, wasn't he?

JA: Yeah. I think he's one of those guys who were the creators. You know two thousand years ago people sat at the foot of someone, you know, the mentor. And you absorbed and you studied in the real world of institutions and university studying. But it wasn't about, you know, go change your schedule so biology is Tuesday and Thursday. So I think, yeah, he was self taught but he created. I mean he used to watch Billy Gladstone and all these great drummers in the pits at Radio City and, you know, he sat and

absorbed. And he also had, all the ingredients were right. The quick wit, the great talent, the genetic and physiological capabilities, the great ear. Just all the ingredients were strong. It's like a great athlete that has it all. You know I remember reading about Schwarzenegger, when he was a world class body builder. But he was on the like championship soccer teams over in Europe. And genetically he was together, but he was a great athlete. So I think when you have all of those strong ingredients you go far. So yeah, Buddy Rich was self taught in that sense, but then we have schools to study people like that. So then you say well I'm educated and he wasn't? No, you can't say that.

MR: Right. Tell me about a couple of people you've worked with. I noticed Donald Fagan on the list.

JA: Yup.

MR: Cool.

JA: Yeah, very cool. I did a gig at a place on 89th Street in New York called Elaine's, that's some posh upper east side place. Frank Vignola, great guitarist, I work a lot with him, we're great friends and do a lot of musical business work together. We were doing a gig, a trio or quartet at Elaine's. I was playing just brushes on a small kit. And in New York people are always coming in and out. So one night Fagan was there. Okay? So then a week or two later we're up in New England on tour and Vignola's manager, at the time he had this road manager, he called my room. "Joe, take this number down, Donald Fagan wants you to call him." "Get the hell out of here." "No, no really." I said, "What are you talking about?" He said, "Well he was at Elaine's, he heard you and he had a hunch." "Oh really?" You know "Libby Times Productions." I said, "Donald Fagan?" "One moment." You hear some French people speaking. Sure enough, "Oh Donald heard you play and do you play R&B?" And you play this, you play that? I said, "Yeah." "Oh because he's putting together a new project, this 'Rock and Soul Revue.'" This was when it first started. And he said he had a hunch. "Can you send us some stuff you've done?" I said, "Sure." So I'm digging through tapes. No, no. So I called a friend and booked a studio, went in the next day, wrote three quick — no I wrote one or two tunes but recorded three tunes, R&B things. And I got Mark Mareno on guitar, Joe Silver on electric bass and myself, and just made like three three-minute demo tunes in that style, and then Federal Expressed it and forgot about it and got the call and they said, "Yeah, that's just what he's looking for." I said wow, that's going to be fun. Next thing I know I'm playing with Jerry Jamat, and the Blues Brothers horn section and Doctor John was there, and all these great — you know Phoebe Snow and Fagan. I'm sitting there, you know, Fagan, wow. He's a musical genius. So that was a great experience. And that's how that happened.

MR: It's wild.

JA: At the time I was studying too, with Bernard Purdie. And I remember him saying — with Bernard Purdie you sit at the drum set, first of all you can never wear sneakers, he'd throw you out. He always said shoes. And he never played the drums, he would just circle like a shark around the prey. And then he would preach. And he'd come out with these pearls of wisdom every like thirty seconds for an hour. And all of a sudden you'd hear him like, "It's not getting the gig, it's keeping the gig." And he'd stop and he'd start preaching again. And he'd come out with these gems you know. So I remember when I told him I got that gig and he was very excited for me and proud. And he also helped me put together how to secure a publishing company for when you write tunes and to get your foot in the door with a record company, given them one tune and learn the ropes. And so that was a great asset. So yeah, the Fagan thing, it was great.

MR: You did live shows?

JA: Yeah, the first show was in New York at the old Lone Star, the one with the iguana outside. And it was a real rush, it really was. That was the first experience I had like the whole group coming together and saying a prayer before going out in front of the — you know it was real hype type stuff. And you know thousands of people out there screaming "Fagan, yo, Steely Dan," they were wanting this tune and that tune. We didn't do those, we did other stuff. But it was great. No playing with people like that it's fantastic. I just recently, well last year, did a gig with Noel Redding, Hendrix's original bass player. So we did, like we were doing Hendrix tunes with Eric Schenkman, the guitarist who founded the Spin Doctors. So it was a power trio. Erick Schenkman from the Spin Doctors, and Noel Redding, and I'm playing drums. It was supposed to be Corky Lange from the old Mountain group who I'm friends with, but he couldn't make it or whatever. So we're playing Hendrix tunes and Beatle tunes and Mountain tunes and at one point I'm starting to weird out, like I'm saying this is Noel Redding, this is as close as I'll ever get to meeting Hendrix you know. So it was a rush. It was great.

MR: That's so funny. Here you are playing—

JA: Yeah and then you're playing "Big Butter and Egg Man" from nineteen twenty something. And you know, well to me, just good music and not good music in any style. We just put labels on it so we could either talk about it or not talk about it. So yeah. No but I just like trying to play the instrument as well as I can and try to plug into musical situations and do as good a job as I can.

MR: Is that what you tell students? I mean do you do much teaching?

JA: I'm part time faculty at the New School for Jazz down in Manhattan. So I have a handful of students there and some private students. I know a lot of professional players who want to come in and work on some technique or work on this or work on that. First I ask them what their goals are and what they're looking to do, and then I kind of make a quick

assessment. I'm a good troubleshooter teacher, if I do say so myself. But I'll sit there and check out a drummer and catch his vibe and see the playing and see if his goals match his style. You know if he's coming in and flipping sticks and bashing drums and double bass riffs, I doubt he's going to be playing in a little quiet jazz trio. He might want to try that because he digs it, but even Charlie Watts now he's playing jazz because he made a trillion dollars with the Stones and now he's doing what he — everybody wanted to be Buddy Rich years ago. You talk to all these great drummers, Simon Phillips and Dennis James and I'm friends with Carly Euder and all these guys and we sit there and talk, and everybody talks about great drummers and that, no, Buddy Rich. So it's funny. But no, to answer your question, I try to see if the external matches the internal, there's some harmony there. And if there's reality. I have one student who said, "Well I want to get better at technique." And I said, "Yeah, okay." "And I want to get more proficient at the gigs and reading." I said, "Yeah." And then he said, and here is the clincher, "And I want to be a rock star." I said, "All right, well the first two we can work on, the third one is a little out of kilter." So but I'll try to point a student in the right direction, but I also believe in being honest. I have one student at the New School that I had for about three semesters. Really tried to help him. And I just had to tell him, "You just better change your major. Do you enjoy writing, both music and prose?" I said, "And you have other talents," and I said, "You know you're at the outset of your college career, perhaps you can take some more liberal arts courses and see where life brings you." I said, "Because unless —" I said, "I'm not saying this just meeting you now," I said, "this is after three semesters of both of us sweating." I said there hasn't been the progress that would be needed. I said you better check other things out.

MR: Yeah. That's a hard thing to do but you're not doing them any favors by not doing it.

JA: No, the truth can hurt sometimes. But it will probably save him a lot of years.

MR: So you say you write some music too?

JA: Yeah.

MR: Do you have any keyboard skills?

JA: Some, yeah. I like arranging and for some reason I hear a lot of melodies so I come up with fairly, borderline catchy to corny, but stuff I've written like this record I did with Joey DeFrancesco and Vignola, a Goodfellows record, I've got three of my tunes on there. It's nice to be appreciated by great players, especially compositionally speaking. So if they accept it then you feel yeah, okay.

MR: It's a nice cover too.

JA: Yeah. And the royalties are good. So yeah, I'll hear a tune in a certain style and then I know what instrument it needs to be played upon, and I just go from there. It all comes together all at once. So it's funny, like one tune I wrote actually it was the title tune of a

Frank Vignola Concord record called "Let it Happen." I wrote this tune "Let it Happen." But we used soprano sax, Arnie Lawrence played that, and David Grisman on mandolin, they played the melody, and John Goldsby acoustic bass, Vignola played a couple of tracks of guitar. And there were no drums. I played bongo, shakers and a couple other things. I didn't hear drums in it. So that was pretty obscure instrumentation. And then we just did a record with Frank Wess and Mark Egan, Frank Vignola.

MR: Frank Wess and Mark Egan.

JA: Yeah, how's that? Well I do a lot of work with Egan, But we do like it's New York at the 55 Bar with Jeff Champlin, it's almost like a Scofieldish, Methaneyish trio. Almost power jazz trios. Pseudo — I don't know what to call it. But we play together. So I got to be good friends with Mark and it's a real treat to play with him and Jeff. And then we play together with Vignola, and did a record with Frank Wess. And I wrote three tunes for this one record, because I was hearing him playing the flute on these tunes. And he was nice enough to do it. So it was great. We licensed three records to — we meaning Frank Vignola and I, we've got this company. And so we got to license a couple of records and so I wrote a couple of tunes on that, and then I did another one, wrote six tunes for this other record. You know every now and then a tune comes up here. I guess I've got a couple of dozen tunes floating out there.

MR: Cool. I see you've worked with Sweets Edison too.

JA: Yeah.

MR: Years ago?

JA: That was exciting too. Because when I was in those Buddy Rich influential days I remember reading something that Sweets was his favorite trumpet player. For whatever that's worth. So I remember getting to meet him and then getting to play with him, I was a little excited, like a little secret under my belt. But yeah, some guys when you play with them boy they just hit one note and it's like oh man you start— I know when something affects me positively I start laughing, I get giddy. So I mean I was giggling the whole time I was playing. Because everything was right. It was — everything was right. It was so easy. So much fun. It was right.

MR: The music scene has changed an awful lot, like since Sweets was a young man, you know. Does it seem healthy to you? I mean you seem to have found a number of niches but is it hopeful for guys in their teens right now that are coming up?

JA: I would think so.

MR: Yeah?

JA: Yeah I would think so. I think it's (a) always been hard, but I don't think too much has changed in the sense that for example I didn't see those days of like the Bucky Pizzarellis, the Milt Hintons, the Russell Georges, the Derek Smiths. These guys did five,

ten studio dates a day for years. I've done one, like in the last two — I did a Barbie doll commercial. My point is, so in that sense I could say, or if you interviewed them and spoke with them twenty, thirty years ago, has it changed for young guys coming up? Yes and no. I never saw those days so maybe kids today won't see what I'm seeing. Like let's say the jazz party scene or jazz festival scene dried up and there's something else. And they would say oh yeah, guys used to do that, and they did a dozen, two dozen of those things a year, meaning let's say jazz festival or party or whatever. You know I've done one they'd say. So in that sense things have changed. But in another sense I think everything is cyclical and there's always work. It manifests itself somehow.

MR: One avenue dries up but something else will hopefully replace it.

JA: Yeah. And musically I like to plug in to different projects. I think that's why when I tried a little Broadway thing I got bored very quickly. When I did some legit work, a little tympani or snare drum, and I have utmost respect for it and I love it, but I get bored quickly. And it's probably my problem. But I don't think it's a problem. What I think it is is I like the spontaneity of the moment and the challenge of the project at hand. So whether it's a gig or a two week engagement or a tour or a festival or a project, plug in, do the best I can, and then there it is and then keep moving. It keeps me interested. I work with Datevik Houanesian, she's an amazing vocalist. Amazing. George Avakian produced her last CD and whew, she's incredible. She does Armenian — indigenous Armenian music, and Brazilian music and jazz music and puts them all together and it works. And I played in L.A. with her, went to Armenia, did the Arivan festival, I've done some gigs in New York right here. She's incredible. My point being here, one minute I'm playing something with brushes with a little jazz trio. Next minute with Fagan or Noel Redding. Next minute a Barbie commercial. And next minute Armenian music. You know and then go play with Mark out at the 55 Bar in New York. And then Dick Hyman calls for 92nd Street Y. And you know, to me there's nothing better, because I'm living my dream, I really am. When I was a kid looking at the records or seeing a drummer on T.V. and I'd say I could do that. I'd look at the record, I want to play that.

MR: And now you're doing it.

JA: Yeah. So things are good. Thank God.

MR: You think there's a future for this jazz party thing?

JA: You know I don't have the answer to that yet but occasionally I think about it. For example I just saw Mat Domber's son here in Clearwater. I think his name is Jeff, sorry Jeff if it's not Jeff. And I see the sons and daughters of the people who run the jazz party scenes. And I always say I wonder if so-and-so is going to take over when so-and-so is not here. So on that side I think it's very possible. And then I say okay, now a lot of people that I know have passed on, audience members, listeners. So in that sense it's

waned quite a bit. Now I've never done one of those Dick Gibson parties. And I used hear like those things were major, tons of people, a slew of musicians, it was a real party. I mean we used to hear about the crazy — in a good way crazy, you know musically and socially. But so everybody's always talking about those days and how it's dried up in a sense that way. And it probably has. And that's why they try to introduce it to young people and try to get them in and things like that. But the jury's out on that as far as I'm concerned. I'm not sure how it's going to go. It looks like it's waning a little bit. But somehow things always creep up. Like this Texas — Odessa and Midland. It's like the Hatfields and the McCoys always battling who's going to do the jazz parties. Now the Jazz Society took it over. So see, something else came up. So I think it's, again, cyclical. That's the way — nothing's static. It's always in a state of change. You've just go to roll with it.

MR: Are you a technology oriented person? Do you use technology that's available for your business?

JA: Yes. I have a computer and I have a BR-8 and I have CD burners, you know midi this and all that and some keyboard hook-ups. But I'd be lying to you if I said I was proficient at it and that it came easily. The irony is I have an engineering degree from New York Institute of Technology. I told you about that itch that I like to scratch. Well I'm here to say for the record I'm the worst engineer that ever existed. And I did work for McDonnell Douglas Aerospace for a bit when I moved to California years ago. And my conscience weighed on me. I said how the hell can I look at a piece of software designed for an airplane and people are on it, and I'm thinking about doing a drum roll. So I said I'd better get the hell out of here. So I did. But what that did was allow me to finish a degree at the time, and that was a good sense of accomplishment. I tried it and dabbled, but it got me enough information to learn a little bit about the gear. So I have some ability on it. But it doesn't come naturally. You know I always thought when I was a kid everything would come naturally like drumming came easily and was comfortable. I thought if I played tennis I can ace every hit. I thought if I hit a pool ball I'd sink it every time. And if I swish a basket I'd never miss. Bit I found out that life isn't like that. You have to work at things. So I'm always amazed at that. I say you know I'm pretty good at this or that, but why can't I do this. Some things you really have to work at. So engineering I would really have to work at, but it's not me. But I have some ability with the technical gear.

MR: If you were going to give a list of must-listen-to drummers, for students, who would have to be on it?

JA: Well what I would first say is instead of just randomly picking a thousand great drummers, I would stop and say let's take the last hundred years and partition it into

musical styles, and let's say we come up with seven to ten styles of music. Because we have Dixieland and swing and bop and progressive and acid jazz and trad. Again labels so we could talk about things. So if we need a label, let's pick some periods in time that the music sounded like this or that or this or that, and let's learn how the music evolved, and then in those certain periods let's pick one or two drummers here and one or two drummers there. You have to hear Baby Dodds. You have to hear Chick Webb. You know there's so many. And now if I say Baby Dodds, Chick Webb and George Wettling, then oh, he left out Tiny Kahn and what about Sid Catlett? So, but that's why I say pick the hundred years that have gone by, pick how the music has evolved and pick a few of the guys. And you have to listen to, in a more contemporary setting, you have to listen to Tony Williams and Roy Haynes and Jack DeJonette and you know, in the big band era you have to listen to Jo Jones and even Chick Webb and Sonny Greer and Gene Krupa. All of them. So I would say obviously all of them, but I would say to do it logically pick, over the hundred years, styles, one or two guys in there, and do some homework and research it. And if they're sincere, we talked about is there a future and what do you tell drummers — if they're interested, people do what they want to do. And when they do something, like I wanted orange juice. Why? Because I really wanted it. So I got it. Something obvious and simple and silly, but if you want to really be a drummer and really know, you're going to seek it out because it excites you. Before I went to college I was following Buddy Rich around, to lug his drums and get laughed at, but yeah, that's what I wanted. So you do what you want. So if a guy really wants to do it, they're going to do it. So if they're interested enough, they'll check it out. Granted they'll probably pick a period where they're most interested, and then from that you start painting this mosaic and you spread out. Like I started with, you know you have to have a starting point and a modeling system let's say. I started with Gene Krupa. And then from there on both sides, pre-Krupa and post-Krupa.

MR: Back and forward.

JA: And today, you know, now, and it's funny because today I'll get into someone way, way back or present, and really try to absorb it, so I get a kick out of how the picture broadens and then you get even specific in certain areas. So yeah.

MR: I've noticed at these festivals and also in the market for classic or mainstream jazz, there seems to be very few black younger players playing this kind of style. Now maybe I'm wrong, but if I'm not, have you noticed that and do you have any reason why that might be?

JA: Well the guys in New York, they're playing a more contemporary style, and I don't know the why, all I can make are statements or observations that are, you know I can infer things. But and I notice some guys for some reason will be drawn towards a Louis

Armstrong versus somebody more contemporary, versus a Dizzy Gillespie let's say. Why I don't know. I think of like Byron Stripling. Monster player. But his itch to scratch wasn't maybe an ass-kicking bop player. I'm sure he digs listening to it and he plays, whatever. But his natural thing was to gravitate. You know I haven't thought about it hard enough to say that it's race related. Just like I picked Krupa, you know when I picked Krupa it's 'cause I heard a sound on a record. My eyes were closed and I heard it. So I'm guessing if Byron heard Louis Armstrong he heard it, he didn't see it. And years ago they said let's go hear so-and-so. Today they go hey did you see— So I don't know if I can answer that question but I'd like to believe, maybe I'm living in a glass bubble here, but I'd like to believe that — 'cause musicians just love to play. So I would think if you asked every musician to pick one or two guys, like I would pick Krupa and Buddy Rich as the start and then right from there it keeps going. But if you ask each guy who do you listen to, even the young black guys or young whoever, there would be a starting point. And then I think the trick is to not be easily influenced by the external. If you have a strong mind you'll stay pure to what was inside and there's no shades involved, it's just what you hear. It's funny because everybody says you learn eighty percent of things with the eyes. But sometimes that can pollute. You know?

MR: That's true.

JA: And all the wonderful people that I meet, musicians and non-musicians alike, they transcend all the baloney. And that's good. I think it's good. I'll have tears in my eyes if I listen to Joe Wilder or Warren Vache.

MR: Good statement.

JA: Yeah.

MR: What's coming up in the near future for you?

JA: The near future. Wow. A couple of weeks in Germany, a couple of concerts in Sweden, a couple of more record dates, sorry for being so vague. I don't want to say more of the same but more of the same but I mean that in a great way. I mean it in a good way. Some good tours, I'm developing these projects with Vignola, Frank Vignola, some of the technology things. And I look at my calendar year to year and I say yeah I did this, yeah okay this year I came full circle but this happened and that happened. I remember when I was a kid I said wow, I had a big band rehearsal and I have a gig next week. Cool. And then the year later, wow I'm plugged in and I did the little symphony thing and oh I'm giving a lesson too. Ahh good. Hey I've got a New Year's gig and this jazz guy called me to sit in. Wow I got a Sonny's gig with so-and-so from the Basie band. And every year it gets better and better and more fulfilling. So hopefully that's what's ahead. Keep moving in that direction.

MR: Well it's been fun talking to you.

JA: Likewise, thank you.

MR: I appreciate it.

JA: My pleasure.

MR: And as I said, I'm still jealous. Keep doing it.

JA: I will. I will. That's all I could do. Thank you.